



GUKESH'S 'DATE' WITH DESTINY

IF THE MEN'S CANDIDATES WINNER BEATS DING THIS YEAR, HE WILL BECOME INDIA'S SECOND WORLD CHESS CHAMPION.

country's flagship event, Gukesh and Arjun found themselves among the top 10 players in the world. When the new FIDE rankings are released on May 1, 2024, Gukesh will be ranked sixth, two ahead of Arjun. Going back to the days when Gukesh began his ascent, he had to contend with coming second to Arjun in the 2022 International Open. Gukesh produced a series of title-winning performances in Spain, where he won a hat-trick of titles by beating the field in the La Roda tournament, the Menorca Open, and the Sunway Formentera

International tournament. This boosted Gukesh's ratings and confidence, and soon he reached the brink of the top 50. More than the rise in rating, what helped Gukesh catch the attention of the chess world was his stupendous showing in the Chess Olympiad in Mamallapuram. Playing on the top board, he won the first eight rounds, with World No. 2 Fabiano Caruana being his most illustrious victim. He went on to win the gold medal and collect the team bronze. Last year, Gukesh became the youngest to reach 2750 in ratings and

Acing the challenge: D. Gukesh won the 2024 FIDE Candidates after a draw against Hikaru Nakamura (USA), with Ian Nepomniachtchi (Russia) and Fabiano Caruana (USA) also drawing their match. MARIA EMELIANOVA

soon overtook Anand in the world rankings. It was the first time in 37 years that Anand was second to an Indian in the rankings. The year also saw Gukesh's long-time coach, Vishnu Prasanna, assume the role of mentor and pave the way for the youngster to take the services of Polish Grandmaster Grzegorz Gajewski, as suggested by Anand. In the World Cup, Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa, Vidit Gujrathi, and Erigaisi produced what was the biggest advertisement for Indian chess by reaching the quarterfinals. Eventually, Praggnanandhaa reached the final

and qualified for the Candidates.

What followed was a tough phase for Gukesh. His form deserted him. The youngster was desperate to meet the rising expectations of qualifying for the Candidates, but the pressure took its toll. Keen to take one of the qualifying spots for Candidates from the Grand Swiss, Gukesh tried too hard, but the event proved a disaster. Starting as the fifth seed, armed with a rating of 2758 in a very strong field, Gukesh finished 81st. His performance rating was 2578, and he lost 26 rating points. This was also the event where Vidit performed exceptionally well to win and qualify for the Candidates. In the London Chess Classic, Gukesh started as the top seed in the 10-player field and eventually finished